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INTRODUCTION



Mourning in America

Serious, critical history tends to be hard on the living. It challenges us to see distortions embedded in the heroic national origin myths we have been taught since childhood. It takes enemies demonized by previous generations and treats them as worthy of understanding in their particular contexts. Ideological absolutes—civility and savagery, liberty and tyranny, and especially us and them—begin to blur. People from our own society who are not supposed to matter, and whose historical experiences show how the injustices of the past have shaped the injustices of the present, move from the shadows into the light. Because critical history challenges assumptions and authority, it often leaves us feeling uncomfortable. Yet it also has the capacity to help us become more humble and humane.

There always have been and always will be reactionaries who accuse the tellers of such histories of iconoclasm. Today, such critics might make the charge of revisionism or political correctness. To defenders of the status quo, it does not matter if the origin myth or national history is untrue or hurtful to those it leaves out or vilifies. The point is that the story upholds the traditional social order by teaching that the rulers came by their position heroically, righteously, and even with the blessing of the divine. Such themes are favored by those guarding their privilege against the supposed barbarians at the gates.

Frank James aimed to rattle those very gates when he rose to speak at the First National Day of Mourning held in Plymouth, Massachusetts, on Thanksgiving Day in 1970. At forty-six years old, he had in some ways been preparing for this moment his entire life. He was born into the Wampanoag community of Aquinnah (or Gay Head), which, despite three centuries of white colonization, had managed to persevere on its ancestral lands on a remote peninsula on the island of Martha's Vineyard. When James was a child, Wampanoag elders could still recall bitterly how in the late 1860s and early 1870s Massachusetts had eliminated their legal status as Indians and turned their centuries-old reservations into two towns, Gay Head and Mashpee (on Cape Cod). The state's expectation was that terminating the reservations would finally make Indians as a group vanish, as nature supposedly intended, by bringing their land into the market and forcing them to scatter and assimilate among the larger American population. Not surprisingly, after that transition, Mashpee and Gay Head ranked among the poorest communities in Massachusetts. Many of the people had indeed left home in search of work, love, or escape. Most of them, however, visited home regularly and intended to return permanently someday, an option they retained because a few stalwarts steadfastly remained where they were, refusing to disappear.¹

James's parents raised him to stand up against a society that denied who he was, misrepresented or ignored his people's past, and saddled Indian children with low expectations. He remembered them counseling him, "You must succeed—your face is a different color in this small Cape Cod community." He did just that. At fourteen years old, he adopted the Wampanoag name of Wamsutta, in honor of the Wampanoag *sachem* (or chief) who in the 1660s began organizing a multitribal resistance to colonization, contrary to the English alliance brokered by his father, Ousamequin, or Massasoit. In other words, from a young age James envisioned himself standing up and defending his people.²

At the same time, he figured out how to thrive in the white world. He served in the U.S. Coast Guard Auxiliary during World War II, carrying on a long tradition of Wampanoag volunteers fighting in the wars of the United States and its colonial predecessors. Then he pursued his early love for music, especially trumpet, all the way to the prestigious New England Conservatory of Music in Boston, only to discover when he graduated in 1948 that no national orchestra would hire him because of racial segregation. Undaunted, he returned to Wampanoag country to become a music teacher and then director of music in the Nauset regional schools on Cape Cod.

But those were just his day jobs. His passion was political activism to improve the lives of the Wampanoags and other indigenous people. To that end, he served as president of the Federated Eastern Indian League, a multitribal organization that sponsored youth activities and scholarships and published a monthly newsletter of happenings throughout Indian country. James also devoted his time to the study of history, knowing that a better understanding of the past was critical to reforming the present. Delving into the classic primary source accounts written by the colonists of Plymouth, what he read made his blood boil, for the true history bore little relation to the supposed tale of Thanksgiving that weighed around his people's neck like a millstone.³

By the time of James's childhood, the American holiday of Thanksgiving had become associated with an origin myth in which the Wampanoags played an important if supporting role. Yet that was not always the case. During the eighteenth century and the first half of the nineteenth, Thanksgiving had no link whatsoever with Pilgrims and Indians. It was a regional holiday, observed only in the New England states or those in the Midwest to which New Englanders had migrated. Individual states decided whether and when they would hold the holiday, though the traditional time was

late November to mark the close of the agricultural year. The so-called First Thanksgiving, as a 1621 gathering of English colonists and Wampanoags has come to be known, was not the root of this holiday. Thanksgiving celebrations had emerged, ironically, out of the English puritan practice of declaring *fast days* of prayer to mark some special mercy or judgment from God. Running from one afternoon to the next, these fast days, or days of Thanksgiving, centered on churchgoing, solemnity, and piety, not gluttony and sport, though they usually concluded at sundown of the second day with a community feast. Gradually, during the colonial era, New Englanders began to hold days of Thanksgiving annually each spring and autumn instead of episodically, and the fasting became less strictly observed. The only continuities between the Thanksgivings of early New England and today's celebration are the gathering of family and friends to break bread and reflect on the goodness of our lives.⁴

The character of the holiday began to change only around the time of the Civil War. In 1863 President Abraham Lincoln declared that the last Thursday of November should be held as a national day of Thanksgiving, apparently in response to intense lobbying by Sarah Josepha Hale, the editor of *Godey's Lady's Book*. Hale believed that the observance would foster unity amid the horrors of the Civil War. Afterward, the tradition stuck, with some modifications to the date, and gradually it spread to the South, too. Around the same time, Americans began to think of the holiday as originating in a feast shared between the English colonists of Plymouth and the surrounding Indians. The first suggestion that such a link existed appears to date to 1841, when the Reverend Alexander Young published the only primary source account of that event, consisting of a mere paragraph of four lines. To it, Young added an influential footnote (perhaps the first and only influential footnote in history) stating that "this was the first Thanksgiving, the harvest festival of

New England.” Over the next fifty years, various authors, artists, and lecturers disseminated Young’s idea until Americans took it for granted.⁵

The lionization of the Pilgrims also grew out of Plymouth town’s attempt to drum up civic pride and tourism. Beginning in 1769, the community’s Old Colony Club began holding an annual Forefathers’ Day on the December 22 anniversary of the Pilgrim landing on Plymouth Rock, as legend would have it. At this event, speeches, toasts, and promotional materials would eulogize the once obscure Pilgrims as the symbolic founders of New England and even the United States by virtue of their religious ideals, commitment to democracy, and resolve to build their colony in the face of adversity. This filiopietistic publicity campaign gradually took hold in Massachusetts, then spread nationally through Yankee writing and orations at the very same time that Americans were beginning to associate Thanksgiving with the Pilgrim saga.⁶

Yet it was one thing for the people of Massachusetts to claim the Pilgrims as forefathers and a dinner between Pilgrims and Indians as the template for a national holiday. It was quite another for the rest of the nation to go along. For that to occur, the United States first had to complete its subjugation of the tribes of the Great Plains and far West. Only then could its people stop vilifying Indians as bloodthirsty savages and give them an unthreatening role in the national founding myth. The Pilgrim saga also had utility in the nation’s culture wars. It was no coincidence that authorities began trumpeting the Pilgrims as national founders amid widespread anxiety that the country was being overrun by Catholic and then Jewish immigrants unappreciative of America’s Protestant, democratic origins and unfamiliar with its values. Depicting the Pilgrims as the epitome of colonial America also served to minimize the country’s long-standing history of racial oppression at a time when Jim Crow was working to return blacks in the South to as close a

state of slavery as possible, and racial segregation was becoming the norm nearly everywhere else. Focusing on the Pilgrims' noble religious and democratic principles, instead of on the shameful Indian wars and systems of slavery more typical of the colonies, enabled whites to think of the so-called black and Indian problems as southern and western exceptions to an otherwise inspiring national heritage. Though Americans eventually assumed that the Thanksgiving holiday and myth had marched together in an unbroken succession since 1621, those traditions were very much products of white Protestants, particularly northerners, asserting their cultural



Jennie Augusta Brownscombe, *The First Thanksgiving*, 1914. Pilgrim Hall Museum, Plymouth, Massachusetts.

Filiopietistic depictions of the "First Thanksgiving" began proliferating in the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries as the Thanksgiving myth gained popularity. Note such historical inaccuracies as the Wampanoags appearing in Plains Indian garb (like feather headdresses and fringed buckskin), the log cabin, the tablecloth, and fine furniture. The actual feast was an earthier, more rambunctious affair than the pious, domestic scene portrayed here.

authority over European immigrants and Americans of color in the nineteenth and early twentieth centuries.⁷

Regardless of whether James was familiar with this background to the holiday, he certainly understood the ideological work of its origin story. In the standard telling, a band of pious Englishmen, referred to as Pilgrims, were so desperate for religious liberty that they were willing to brave the dangers of the angry Atlantic and the howling wilderness to build a new society in America. Dissent spread through their ranks once they realized that they had to land well north of their intended destination on the Hudson River, so they drew up an agreement, signed by all the male passengers, in which everyone pledged to abide by the rule of a democratically elected government. Generations of American schoolchildren have read the colonist William Bradford's account of how he and his fellow English did "solemnly and mutually in the presence of God and one another, covenant and combine ourselves together into a civil body politic, for our better ordering . . . to enact, constitute, and frame such just and equal laws . . . from time to time, as shall be thought most meet and convenient for the general good of the colony, unto which we promise all due submission and obedience." This Mayflower Compact (named after the colonists' ship) thus became the supposed model for the American Constitution. It was just the first of the sojourners' many trials. Sea-tossed, thin, and tattered, they finally arrived on the shores of Cape Cod hoping to make contact with the Indians and trade for food, but the Natives kept their distance. And so the English spent their first winter half starving and lost half their numbers to disease.⁸

Then a near miracle happened. For some reason, the Indians (rarely identified by tribe) overcame their caution and proved to be "friendly" (requiring no explanation), led by the translators Samoset and Squanto and Massasoit, their chief. They fed the English and taught them how to plant corn and where to fish, at which point the

colony began to thrive. The two parties then sealed their newfound friendship with a feast that came to be known as the First Thanksgiving. The peace that followed permitted colonial New England and, by extension, modern America to become seats of freedom, democracy, Christianity, and plenty. As for what happened to the Indians, this myth has nothing to say. Their legacy was to present America as a gift to others or, in other words, to concede to colonialism. Like Pocahontas and Sacajawea (the other most famous Indians), they helped the colonizers and then moved offstage.⁹

Literally. Throughout James's lifetime American schools had elementary students perform annual Thanksgiving pageants in which they dressed up as Pilgrims (replete with oversized buckles on every conceivable article of clothing) and Indians (costumed as if they were from the Great Plains) to make friendship and launch the United States. Though some twenty-first-century school systems have conscientiously halted these pageants, many others (my admittedly unscientific surveys of students and primary school teachers suggests that the number is about half) continue the ritual. I myself



Enrico Causici, *Landing of the Pilgrims*, 1620, 1825. Courtesy of the Architect of the Capitol.

The myth of friendly Indians welcoming the Pilgrims is such a fundamental part of Americans' sense of themselves that it is depicted in relief in the rotunda of the United States Capitol.

remember participating in such a pageant, which closed with the song "My Country 'Tis of Thee," whose first verse reads: "My country, 'tis of thee / Sweet land of liberty / Of thee I sing. / Land where my fathers died! / Land of the Pilgrim's pride! / From every mountain-side, / Let freedom ring!" Having a diverse group of schoolchildren sing about the Pilgrims as "my fathers" was designed to teach them about who we, as Americans, are, or least who we're supposed to be. Even students from discrete ethnic backgrounds would be instilled with the principles of representative government, liberty, and Christianity while learning to identify with English colonists from four hundred years ago as fellow whites.¹⁰

Leaving Indians out of the category of "my fathers" also carried important lessons. It was yet another reminder about which race ran the country and whose values mattered. Lest we dismiss the impact of these messages, consider the experience of a young Wampanoag woman who in 2017 told this author that when she was in kindergarten, the lone Indian in her class, her teacher cast her as Massasoit in one of these pageants and had her sing with her classmates "this land is your land, this land is my land." Reflecting on the moment as an adult, the cruel irony was not lost on her. As a child, she only knew enough to be embarrassed about it.¹¹

Like so many Indians of his time and ours, it rankled Frank James that the ideologically loaded caricature of friendly Indians inviting the Pilgrims to colonize was practically the only cameo Indians made in the school curriculum. To the extent that social studies instructors addressed Indians at all, it was in the context of the narrative of Manifest Destiny, in which they appeared as primitive savages fated to make way for a more enlightened people. There was no discussion of the civilizations they had created over thousands of years before the arrival of Europeans or how they suffered under and resisted colonization. There was especially no treatment of how they had managed to survive, adapt, and become part of

modern society while maintaining their Indian identities and defending their indigenous rights. Every Thanksgiving season, Wampanoag and other Indian students throughout the United States had to listen to their teachers deny their history and even who they were. Wampanoags today commonly tell of their parents objecting to the performance of Thanksgiving pageants and associated history lessons that the New England Indians were all gone, only to have schoolteachers and principals respond to them with puzzlement and even hostility. Officials often seemed incredulous that the children and their caregivers were actual Indians. The only authentic Indians were supposed to be primitive relics, not modern, so what were they doing in school, speaking English, wearing the same kind of clothing as their classmates, living in contemporary houses, or returning home to adults who had jobs and drove cars? Year after year, generation after generation, Indian schoolchildren have had to suffer this sort of devaluation from the very authority figures who are supposed to be looking out for their interests.¹²

So when James received an invitation to deliver a speech to a Massachusetts state banquet to be held in September 1970, in celebration of the 350th anniversary of Plymouth colony's founding, he saw it as a rare opportunity to set the record straight. Yet, when he submitted a draft of the speech for review, the deputy director of the state Department of Commerce and Development rejected it as "too inflammatory" for the occasion. James, for his part, found an alternative speech drawn up by officials to be so "childish and untrue," and attempts at collaborative rewriting to be so pointless, that he pulled out of the event altogether. He was not going to be yet another Indian prop at an event celebrating the start of his people's demise. Instead, he began laying down plans for a commemoration where there would be no censors.¹³

During the late 1960s, Indians across the country drew inspiration from the black civil rights movement to launch their own



Chestnut Street School Thanksgiving, Portland, 1924.

Collections of Maine Historical Society.

Thanksgiving pageants, in which elementary school children dramatize the mythical Pilgrim-Indian encounter, have been an American tradition since the early twentieth century. The not-so-subtle message is that Indians welcomed colonization, that New England colonists were the progenitors of the United States, and that the values of Christianity, democracy, and white authority are timeless.

campaigns for Indian sovereignty and dignity, or Red Power, as it became known. The first, most visible sign of this campaign came in 1969 when dozens of Indians from San Francisco and nearby colleges occupied the old prison on Alcatraz Island, which they claimed by virtue of a clause in the 1868 Treaty of Fort Laramie pledging the government to return retired or abandoned federal land to Native peoples. Ultimately, they did not get the island or the cultural center they demanded, but during their fourteen-month protest they did draw an unprecedented amount of attention to Indian causes, which was the point. Meanwhile, Native activists in Minneapolis formed the American Indian Movement (AIM) to combat police harassment locally and the federal government's violation of Indian treaties nationally. Within a few years, AIM

became a magnet for publicity, leading a brief takeover of the Bureau of Indian Affairs in Washington, D.C., in 1972, and then a lengthier, more violent occupation of the South Dakota village of Wounded Knee, site of the 1890 massacre of a band of Minneconjou Lakotas by the U.S. Seventh Cavalry for nothing more than holding an unauthorized dance. All across the country, Indians were declaring that they had had enough of being “at the very bottom” of American society.¹⁴

The next chapter belonged to Frank James. Reaching out to Wampanoag and Narragansett leaders, and even to the nascent AIM organization, he organized a “National Day of Mourning” to take place on Thanksgiving Day 1970 in Plymouth at the site of the Massasoit statue on Cole’s Hill overlooking Plymouth Rock. He intended this event to serve as a counterpoint to the Pilgrim Progress march held each Thanksgiving since 1920, in which Pilgrim descendants in colonial costume made their way through Plymouth town to the cemetery of their ancestors, followed by a church service. The name, Day of Mourning, harked back not only to the recent National Days of Mourning held throughout the United States after the assassinations of President John F. Kennedy in 1963 and Martin Luther King Jr. in 1968. It also evoked the *Eulogy on King Philip* written in 1836 by William Apess, a Pequot preacher and activist who served the Wampanoag community of Mashpee. In his *Eulogy*, Apess declared the December 22, 1620, anniversary of the Pilgrims’ landing and the Fourth of July to be “days of mourning and not joy” for Indians because of the evils whites had done to them. When James’s moment finally came, he, like Apess incarnate, rose up before two hundred protestors from all across Indian country, media, and onlookers, and delivered the “inflammatory speech” that Massachusetts had tried to suppress.¹⁵

He began with the most poignant assertion of all, that he had the right to the dignity of his humanity despite society’s efforts to

diminish him and his people. "I speak to you as a man," he emphasized, "a Wampanoag man. I am a proud man, proud of my ancestry, my accomplishments won by a strict parental direction," even as his family and community suffered "poverty and discrimination, two social and economic diseases." He acknowledged to his white listeners that Thanksgiving "is a time of celebration for you—celebrating the beginnings for the white man in America." For James and his the Wampanoags, the day had doleful implications. "It is with a heavy heart," he explained, "that I look back on what happened to my people."¹⁶

James then proceeded to tell a history of English-Wampanoag relations that turned the bedtime story of the Thanksgiving myth into a nightmare. The European mariners called "explorers" by historians were in fact slavers who raided the Wampanoag coast for years before the Pilgrims' arrival, capturing people for sale to distant places of which they had never heard. The Plymouth colonists were no better, despite their claims to piety. They introduced themselves

Frank James in front of Massasoit statue at the
1974 National Day of Mourning protest.
Courtesy of the *Enterprise*. Photograph by
Craig Murray.



to the Wampanoags by desecrating graves and robbing seed corn from underground storage barns. Nevertheless, Massasoit extended a peaceful hand to the newcomers, not out of innate friendliness but pity, and because his people needed allies against their Narragansett Indian rivals after the Wampanoags suffered a devastating epidemic introduced by Europeans. This horror was the dark background to the supposed First Thanksgiving.¹⁷

James saw little in this history to celebrate. "The action by Massasoit," he proposed, "was perhaps our biggest mistake. We the Wampanoags welcomed you, the white man, with open arms, little knowing it was the beginning of the end; that before 50 years were to pass, the Wampanoag would no longer be a free people." The dishes had barely been cleared from the First Thanksgiving before a litany of English crimes began to mount: atrocities like the New England colonists' 1637 massacre of the Pequots at Mystic Fort, which Connecticut and Massachusetts memorialized with a day of thanksgiving; cheating Indians out of their land, herding them onto reservations, and making them trespassers in their own country; exploiting Indian poverty and English control of the courts to force Indians into servitude; degrading Indians by calling them savages at every opportunity. To James, like Apess, the moral of the First Thanksgiving was that the English and their descendants betrayed the Wampanoags who had once befriended them in their time of need.¹⁸

The question was and still is how to move forward. The answer, according to Frank James, is to confront this history, including the fact that, as he put it, "we the Wampanoag still walk the lands of Massachusetts . . . our spirit refuses to die." James also urged the American public to consider Indians as deserving of respect as everyone else, including their colonizers. "Let us remember," counseled James, "the Indian is and was as human as the white man. The Indian feels pain, gets hurt, and becomes defensive,

has dreams, bears tragedy and failure, suffers from loneliness, needs to cry as well as laugh." If Americans took the simple step of extending compassion to their Indian countrymen and countrywomen, it would make Thanksgiving Day 1970 a new beginning toward "a more humane America, a more Indian America," in which Native people could "regain the position in this country that is rightfully ours." This was a stirring message for indigenous people unaccustomed to hearing their beliefs articulated so forcefully before the general public.¹⁹

To James's chagrin, the event he organized turned into something other than just a time of mournful reflection and teaching. Some speakers, including the AIM provocateur Russell Means, wanted less talking and more action, declaring that "Plymouth Rock is red. Red with our blood!" and that "today you will see the Indian reclaim the *Mayflower* in a symbolic gesture to reclaim our rights in this country." He wasn't kidding. Charging down Cole's Hill to the harbor, a body of protestors buried Plymouth Rock with sand, then took over a replica of the *Mayflower* anchored at a nearby wharf. Into the water went a small cannon and a mannequin representing Captain Christopher Jones, while other activists scaled the rigging to rip down the flags of Old England. Eventually, police managed to clear the ship of protestors, only to have other Indians march drumming and singing to the Plimoth Plantation living history museum, where they disrupted a traditional Thanksgiving dinner by overturning some tables and carrying off four cooked turkeys, all the while whooping and shouting like warriors. Some of the activists even made a second assault on Plymouth Rock, painting it red. James was no shrinking violet—a bumper sticker on his car read "Custer Had It Coming"—but he felt that "national Indians" had taken things too far and left local Indians to deal with the fallout.²⁰

Nevertheless, there was no question that James's National Day of Mourning had made its mark. Indigenous people and their

supporters have observed it in Plymouth on every Thanksgiving since 1970 with robust national media coverage. In any given year, there are representatives from Native communities throughout the continent and even the hemisphere who recognize that their local struggles are part of an ongoing global indigenous fight against colonial assaults on their sovereignty, land, sacred sites, and cultural self-direction. Furthermore, many Indians across the United States have joined the Wampanoags in treating Thanksgiving as a time for mournful remembrance and gratitude toward the Creator.²¹

James wanted the public to understand and sympathize with why some Wampanoags and other Native Americans mourn on a day on which other Americans express thankfulness for the good in their lives. We all would be wise to take heed. It is lazy and downright wrong to dismiss the National Day of Mourning as a spectacle without substance. No doubt, some participants over the years have sought publicity and got it for such actions as placing Ku Klux Klan sheets on the statue of the Plymouth colony governor William Bradford. Yet the point of such actions has been to punctuate the deeper messages of grief and solidarity for Native Americans, and understanding, compassion, and the value of daily gratitude among Americans of all descriptions.²²

There are so many reasons for the American public to follow James's example and attempt to reflect on the history of Plymouth and Thanksgiving with three-dimensional Wampanoags at the center. Thanksgiving eclipses Columbus Day as the one time a year when the country considers the Native American role in the nation's past. It is bad enough to have gotten the story so wrong for so long. It is inexcusable to continue the annual tradition of having a phalanx of teachers, politicians, and television producers traffic in the Thanksgiving myth, and homeowners and shopping centers sport decorations of happy Indians and Pilgrims. These practices dismiss Native peoples' real historical traumas in favor of depicting their

ancestors as consenting to colonialism. To call the consequences harmless is to ignore the chorus of Native Americans, our fellow Americans after all, who say the hurt is profound, particularly to their children. This is a population that has suffered more than its fair share in the creation of the United States. Additionally, Indian men and, nowadays, women, have served in the military at exceptionally high rates in every single one of the nation's wars. In a pluralistic country, it is morally unacceptable to allow the celebration of a national holiday to damage part of the nation's people, never mind the First People.

Or, for that matter, all of the people. Whereas the identity politics of marginalized groups tends to focus on achieving justice and equality (or, in the Indian case, sovereignty), white identity politics has always—always—centered on oppressing others. Yet there has been too little public consideration about how the Thanksgiving myth teaches white proprietorship of the nation. Why should a school-age child with the last name of, say, Silverman, identify more with the Pilgrims than the Indians? After all, such a student is unlikely to descend from either group, and the descendants of both groups are Silverman's fellow Americans. If the student is taught to think of *both* Pilgrims and Indians more dispassionately as "they" instead of "we," it might be a step toward a more critical understanding of history in which all the actors can be seen as fully human, with all the virtues and shortcomings that one would expect to find in any population. At the same time, if the student is taught to think of both groups more inclusively as "we," it might contribute to a more compassionate national culture. This vision would include school curricula that treat Native American history as basic to an understanding of American history in general rather than something to be discussed only at Thanksgiving or Native American Heritage Month. Such a shift might also feature bringing Indians and their concerns into the national conversation, including having

presidential candidates hold a serious discussion about their Indian policies and the state of Indian country, something this author has never seen in his lifetime.

If the public continues to insist on associating Pilgrim-Wampanoag relations with Thanksgiving, the least we can do is try to get the story right. The challenge is significant, at several different levels. Part of it has to do with the limits of historical sources, which at best make recovering the Native American past difficult, and at worst make it impossible. The Wampanoags, despite acquiring a remarkable level of alphabetic literacy during the seventeenth and eighteenth centuries, did not produce many surviving historical documents. English colonists and later white Americans—including missionaries, bureaucrats, merchants, curious travelers, and academics—created the vast majority of the written records on which historians rely. Though some of them knew the Wampanoags and their culture well, most of them did not, and though some of them believed that they had the Wampanoags' interests at heart, most of them did not. Furthermore, outsiders' accounts often ignored key aspects of Wampanoag life, such as women's roles, childhood, aging, local politics, and relations between Native communities. Other sources, including oral histories and archaeological findings, can help compensate for these biases and silences, but even then there remains so much essential information that will never be known. Until the 1970s, very few professional historians bothered to correct the record because they saw Indians as irrelevant to the story of the United States and the modern world. Better to leave indigenous people to the anthropologists across campus. Since then, however, the historical field has awakened to the dynamism and centrality of the Native American past and developed methodologies to use every possible source to recount it as best we can.²³

This book operates under the premise that imperfect histories of Indian life are better than no histories. Acknowledging that many

Wampanoag voices and perspectives are distorted or selectively represented by the historical record is not the same thing as saying that they are absent. Indeed, they exist in greater volume than one might assume, because, from the 1620s up to the present day, the people had a remarkable knack for figuring out ways to get their points across even under trying circumstances. The fact that their history played out in a remarkably literate region, divided into several colonies and religious factions, each with their own take on Indian affairs, and blessed by a relative lack of destructive wars and severe weather incidents, has produced a rich archive with multiple vantages on Indian topics.

The customary division of American history into eras determined by the national story of the United States also obstructs our effort to understand the Native American past on its own terms. Traditionally, American history has relegated the Wampanoags to Plymouth's early years at the start of the "colonial period." To the extent that Wampanoags appear after that time, it is only in discussions of the devastating King Philip's War of 1675–76. The implication is that the people no longer mattered after their defeat, that they had all been killed or somehow disappeared. A truly Wampanoag-centered history of Plymouth and Thanksgiving requires extending the historical chronology in two directions. Rather than beginning with English contact, as if the Wampanoags were frozen in time, waiting for history to start with European colonization of the so-called New World, this book contends that centuries-long developments among the Wampanoags help explain how they behaved after the English arrival. In other words, it sees the Wampanoags as having emerged from an Indian Old World every bit as ancient and important as the past of Europe.

Additionally, this book, despite its focus on the seventeenth century, traces Wampanoag history after the Thanksgiving feast and King Philip's War up to the present day. This approach emphasizes

that, for the Wampanoags and other Indians, the colonial period did not end in 1776 with the American Declaration of Independence. Nor did it close following the creation or termination of their reservations. Native Americans are still experiencing colonization. They still have to take periodic legal action to exercise sovereignty over their land and people because too many of their fellow Americans consider such rights to be relics of a bygone era. Many Indians continue to fight state and federal governments to recover territory seized from them in violation of historical treaties that are supposed to be the basis of their government-to-government relationship with Washington. And they still battle to revitalize their languages and cultures in the face of generations of governmental and popular pressure to assimilate and disappear.²⁴

Though this book focuses on historical Wampanoags and strives to include their voices at every opportunity, the reader should be fully aware that the author is not Wampanoag and this is not a history told from a modern Wampanoag perspective. My conversations with modern Wampanoags have informed the content, but there is material in this book that some Wampanoags will consider dubious, outright wrong, and perhaps none of my business as an outsider. I have done my best to take those criticisms into consideration by soliciting responses to drafts of this book from historically minded Wampanoag colleagues and discussing my ideas with Wampanoag audiences open to hearing them. I have offered to include dissenting opinions alongside my interpretations, all the while acknowledging that the playing field is uneven given that I am the author. Ultimately, the responsibility for all editorial decisions in this book belong to me alone, and in the final analysis I have made tough decisions based on the standards of my discipline of history. I urge my readers to seek out the Wampanoags' own tellings of this history, which are widely available in print, film, and online, as cited in my endnotes. My hope is that Wampanoag and other indigenous

readers will see an informed, well-intentioned attempt to fulfill the Indian call to take Indian history seriously in the context of a greater American history. Doing so necessarily includes addressing issues that remain controversial and contested among readers of all descriptions. Again, critical history can be hard on the living. But, as one gracious Aquinnah Wampanoag elder once told me, “we do ourselves no good by hiding from the truth.” I think she meant all of us. Amen.

THIS LAND IS THEIR LAND

**THE WAMPANOAG INDIANS,
PLYMOUTH COLONY, AND THE TROUBLED
HISTORY OF THANKSGIVING**

DAVID J. SILVERMAN

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